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Limpopo



Western Cape



Gauteng



forestry, fisheries
& the environment

Department:
Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA



Natural

iSimangaliso Wetland Park

Inscription: 1999

Criteria: (v) (ix) (x)

Location: KwaZulu-Natal Province



Description:

The ongoing fluvial, marine and aeolian processes in the site have produced a variety of landforms, including coral reefs, long sandy beaches, coastal dunes, lake systems, swamps, and extensive reed and papyrus wetlands. The interplay of the park's environmental heterogeneity with major floods and coastal storms and a transitional geographic location between subtropical and tropical Africa has resulted in exceptional species diversity and ongoing speciation. The mosaic of landforms and habitat types creates breathtaking scenic vistas. The site contains critical habitats for a range of species from Africa's marine, wetland and savannah environments.

Cape Floral Region Protected Areas

Inscription: 2004, 2015

Criteria: (ix) (x)

Location: Western and Eastern Cape Province



Description:

It is one of the world's great centres of terrestrial biodiversity. The extended property includes national parks, nature reserves, wilderness areas, State forests and mountain catchment areas. These elements add a significant number of endemic species associated with the *Fynbos* vegetation, a fine-leaved sclerophyllic shrubland adapted to both a Mediterranean climate and periodic fires, which is unique to the Cape Floral Region.

Vredefort Dome

Inscription: 2005

Criteria: (viii)

Location: North West and Free State Province



Description:

is a representative part of a larger meteorite impact structure, or astrobleme. Dating back 2,023 million years, it is the oldest astrobleme yet found on Earth. With a radius of 190 km, it is also the largest and the most deeply eroded. Vredefort Dome bears witness to the world's greatest known single energy release event, which had devastating global effects including, according to some scientists, major evolutionary changes. It provides critical evidence of the Earth's geological history and is crucial to understanding of the evolution of the planet. Despite the importance of impact sites to the planet's history, geological activity on the Earth's surface has led to the disappearance of evidence from most of them, and Vredefort is the only example to provide a full geological profile of an astrobleme below the crater floor.

Barberton Makhonjwa Mountains

Inscription: 2018

Criteria: (viii)

Location: Mpumalanga Province



Description:

The Barberton Makhonjwa Mountains comprises 40% of the Barberton Greenstone Belt, one of the world's oldest geological structures. The property represents the best-preserved succession of volcanic and sedimentary rock dating back 3.6 to 3.25 billion years and forms a diverse repository of information on surface conditions, meteorite impacts, volcanism, continent-building processes and the environment of early life.

Mixed (Natural and Cultural)

Maloti - Drakensberg Park

Inscription: 2000, 2013

Criteria: (i) (iii) (vii) (x)

Location: KwaZulu – Natal Province and Lesotho



Description:

The Maloti-Drakensberg Park is a transnational property composed of the uKhahlamba Drakensberg National Park in South Africa and the Sehlabathebe National Park in Lesotho. The site has exceptional natural beauty in its soaring basaltic buttresses, incisive dramatic cutbacks, and golden sandstone ramparts as well as visually spectacular sculptured arches, caves, cliffs, pillars and rock pools. The site's diversity of habitats protects a high level of endemic and globally important plants. The site harbors endangered species such as the Cape vulture (*Gyps coprotheres*) and the bearded vulture (*Gypaetus barbatus*). Lesotho's Sehlabathebe National Park also harbors the Maloti minnow (*Pseudobarbus quathlambae*), a critically endangered fish species only found in this park. This spectacular natural site contains many caves and rock-shelters with the largest and most concentrated group of paintings in Africa south of the Sahara. They represent the spiritual life of the San people, who lived in this area over a period of 4,000 years.

Cultural

Fossil Hominid Sites of South Africa

- Cradle of Humankind
- Taung Skull
- Makapan Valley

Inscription: 1999, 2005

Criteria: (iii) (vi)

Location: Gauteng, North West and Limpopo Province



Description:

The undulating landscape containing the fossil hominid sites of South Africa comprises dolomitic limestone ridges with rocky outcrops and valley grasslands, wooded along watercourses and in areas of natural springs. Most sites are in caves or are associated with rocky outcrops or water sources. The serial listing includes the Fossil Hominid Sites of Sterkfontein, Swartkrans, Kromdraai and Environs, and the Makapan Valley and Taung Skull Fossil Site. The Taung Skull, found in a limestone quarry at Dart Pinnacle amongst numerous archaeological and palaeontological sites south-west of the Sterkfontein Valley area, is a specimen of the species *Australopithecus Africanus*. Fossils found in the many archaeological caves of the Makapan Valley have enabled the identification of several specimens of early hominids, more particularly of *Paranthropus*, dating back between 4.5 million and 2.5 million years, as well as evidence of the domestication of fire 1.8 million to 1 million years ago. Collectively these sites have produced abundant scientific information on the evolution of modern humans over at least the past 3.5 million years. They constitute a vast reserve of scientific information, with enormous potential.

The sites contain within their deposits all of the key interrelated and interdependent elements in their palaeontological relationships. Alongside and predating the hominid period of occupation is a sequence of fossil mammals, micro-mammals and invertebrates which provide a window onto faunal evolution, palaeobiology and palaeoecology stretching back into the Pliocene. This record has come to play a crucial role in furthering our understanding of human evolution and the appearance of modern human behaviour.

The fossil evidence contained within these sites proves conclusively that the African continent is the undisputed Cradle of Humankind.

Robben Island

Inscription: 1999

Criteria: (iii) (vi)

Location: Western Cape Province



Description:

Robben Island was used at various times between the 17th century and the 20th century as a prison, a hospital for socially unacceptable groups, and a military base. Its buildings, and in particular those of the late 20th century maximum security prison for political prisoners, testify to the way in which democracy and freedom triumphed over oppression and racism.

What survives from its episodic history are 17th century quarries, the tomb of Hadije Kramat who died in 1755, 19th century 'village' administrative buildings including a chapel and parsonage, small lighthouse, the lepers' church, the only remains of a leper colony, derelict World War II military structures around the harbour and the stark and functional maximum-security prison of the Apartheid period began in the 1960s.

The symbolic value of Robben Island lies in its somber history, as a prison and a hospital for unfortunates who were sequestered as being socially undesirable. This came to an end in the 1990s when the inhuman Apartheid regime was rejected by the South African people and the political prisoners who had been incarcerated on the Island received their freedom after many years.

Mapungubwe Cultural Landscape

Inscription: 2003

Criteria: (ii) (iii) (iv) (v)

Location: Limpopo Province



Description:

The Mapungubwe Cultural Landscape demonstrates the rise and fall of the first indigenous kingdom in Southern Africa between 900 and 1,300 AD. The core area covers nearly 30,000 ha and is supported by a suggested buffer zone of around 100,000 ha. Within the collectively known Zhizo sites are the remains of three capitals - Schroda; Leopard's Kopje; and the final one located around Mapungubwe hill - and their satellite settlements and lands around the confluence of the Limpopo and the Shashe rivers whose fertility supported a large population within the kingdom.

Mapungubwe's position at the crossing of the north/south and east/west routes in southern Africa also enabled it to control trade, through the East African ports to India and China, and throughout southern Africa. From its hinterland it harvested gold and ivory - commodities in scarce supply elsewhere - and this brought it great wealth as displayed through imports such as Chinese porcelain and Persian glass beads.

This international trade also created a society that was closely linked to ideological adjustments, and changes in architecture and settlement planning. Until its demise at the end of the 13th century AD, Mapungubwe was the most important inland settlement in the African subcontinent and the cultural landscape contains a wealth of information in archaeological sites that records its development. The evidence reveals how trade increased and developed in a pattern influenced by an elite class with a sacred leadership where the king was secluded from the commoners located in the surrounding settlements.

Mapungubwe's demise was brought about by climatic change. During its final two millennia, periods of warmer and wetter conditions suitable for agriculture in the Limpopo/Shashe valley were interspersed with cooler and drier pulses. When rainfall decreased after 1300 AD, the land could no longer sustain a high population using traditional farming methods, and the inhabitants were obliged to disperse. Mapungubwe's position as a power base shifted north to Great Zimbabwe and, later, Khami.

The remains of this famous kingdom, when viewed against the present-day fauna and flora, and the geomorphological formations of the Limpopo/Shashe confluence, create an impressive cultural landscape of universal significance.

Richtersveld Cultural and Botanical Landscape

Inscription: 2007

Criteria: (iv) (v)

Location: Northern Cape Province



Description:

The extensive communal grazed lands of the Richtersveld Cultural and Botanical Landscape are a testimony to land management processes which have ensured the protection of the succulent Karoo vegetation and thus demonstrates a harmonious interaction between people and nature. Furthermore, the seasonal migrations of graziers between stockposts with traditional demountable mat-roofed houses, |haru oms, reflect a practice that was once much more widespread over Southern Africa, and which has persisted for at least two millennia; the Nama are now its last practitioners.

Khomani Cultural Landscape

Inscription: 2017

Criteria: (v) (vi)

Location: Northern Cape Province



Description:

The Khomani Cultural Landscape is located at the border with Botswana and Namibia in the northern part of the country. The property comprises a vast area that coincides with the Kalahari Gemsbok National Park (KGNP). The large expanse of sand dunes forms a landscape which contains tangible evidence of human occupation from the Stone Age to the present and is associated with the culture of the Khomani and related San people. The landscape includes landmarks of the history, migration, livelihoods, memory and resources of the Khomani and related San people and other communities, past and present, and attests to their adaptive responses and interaction to survive in a desert environment. The Khomani and related San people are formerly nomadic populations and among the last indigenous communities in South Africa. They developed subsistence strategies to cope with the extreme conditions of the environment and developed a specific ethnobotanical and veld knowledge as well as cultural practices and a worldview where geographical features embody symbolic links between humans, wildlife and the land.

The Khomani are actively reclaiming their knowledge, practices and traditions, bringing back to life a rich associative landscape, thanks also to the survival of the last speakers of the !Ui-Taa languages in the Khomani community. The Khomani Cultural Landscape reflects the ethos of the Khomani and related San people of living softly on the land and seeing themselves as part of nature, in a landscape where there is a respectful relationship between humans, plants and animals, links them to this land in a unique way that epitomises sustainability.

The Emergence of Modern Human Behaviour:

The Pleistocene Occupation Sites of South Africa

Inscription: 2024

Criteria: (iii) (iv) (v)

Location: KwaZulu – Natal and Western Cape Province



Description:

Diepkloof Rock Shelter, Pinnacle Point Site Complex, and Sibhudu Cave are three widely dispersed archaeological sites located in the Western Cape and KwaZulu-Natal provinces of South Africa. Two of them, Sibhudu Cave and Diepkloof Rock Shelter, are located about ten kilometres from the current shoreline, while the Pinnacle Point Site Complex is located directly on the coast. These sites provide the most varied and best-preserved record known of the development of modern human behaviour, reaching back as far as 162,000 years. Symbolic thought and advanced technologies are exemplified by evidence of ochre processing, engraved patterns on ochre and bone, estuarine shellfish beads for body decoration, decorated ostrich eggshells, lithic technologies for advanced projectile weapons, heat treatment of stone for toolmaking, and microliths. This serial property contributes to the understanding of the origin of behaviourally modern humans, their cognitive abilities and cultures, and the climatic transitions that they survived.

Human Rights Liberation and Reconciliation: Nelson Mandela Legacy Sites

Inscription: 2024

Criteria: (vi)

Location: Gauteng, KwaZulu – Natal and Eastern Cape Province



Description:

The serial property represents the legacy of the South African struggle for human rights, liberation and reconciliation. It consists of fourteen component parts located around the country, all related to South Africa's political history in the 20th century. The parts include the Union Buildings (Pretoria), now the official seat of government; the Sharpeville Sites, commemorating the massacre of 69 people protesting the unjust Pass Laws; and The Great Place at Mqhekezweni, a site symbolic of traditional leadership where Nelson Mandela lived as a young man. These places reflect key events linked to the long struggle against the apartheid state; Mandela's influence in promoting understanding and forgiveness; and belief systems based on philosophies of non-racialism, Pan-Africanism and ubuntu, a concept that implies humanity is not solely embedded in an individual.

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